Pursuit of such an ambition, of course, hinges on the TRS wresting the Telangana assembly for a third time—a feat that would be a first for any regional party in the south. Conversely, the grander gestures seem part of an attempt to accomplish just that.

With the election mood setting in already, there is speculation that KCR may call for the assembly poll to be held months before it is due in December 2023, just like he did in 2018 before completing his full first term as CM. At one level, this would be a way to beat back the growing anti-incumbency. Having realised, perhaps, that invoking the sacrifices that went into achieving statehood for Telangana may have run its limit, KCR has hired the Indian Political Affairs Committee (I-PAC) of poll strategist Prashant Kishor to try and turn the tide with some good, old propaganda.

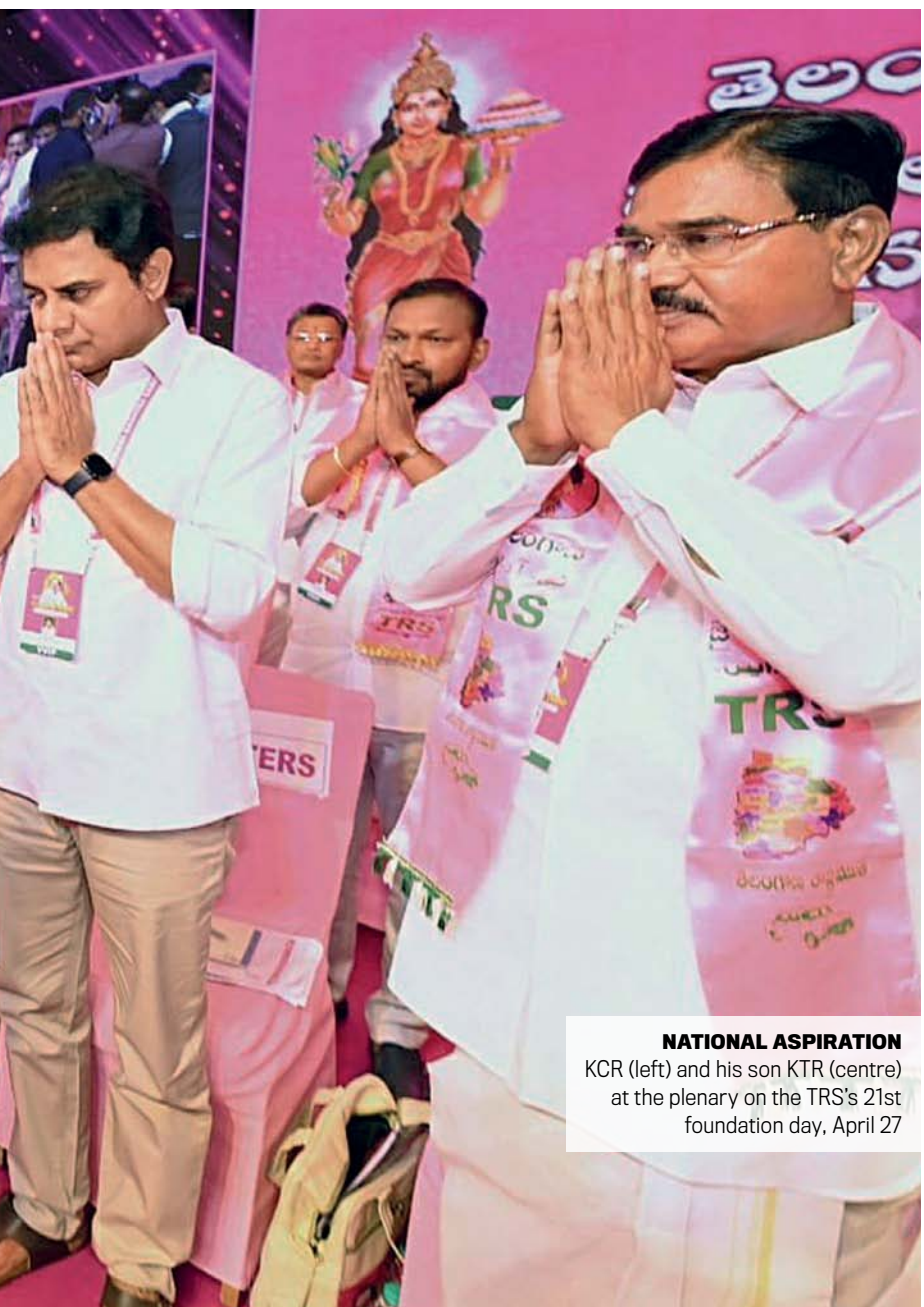
AN ALTERNATIVE AGENDA

The party's foundation day was a perfect platform to put out some high rhetoric about essaying a path-breaking role in a potential national alternative, which would "create a political storm in the country". To set the alternative agenda, he plans to host an international conference of renowned economists and 2,000-odd retired bureaucrats. There was little in what KCR said at the plenary, or in the 13 resolutions adopted there, to suggest a concrete governance agenda though. Twelve of the resolutions focused on targeting the NDA government at the Centre. One demanded that the pioneering Dalit Bandhu scheme, which provides a grant of Rs 10 lakh to every Dalit family in Telangana, be implemented across India.

"Many people are waiting for me to announce a political front...like the process taken for Telangana, this also needs some process. Only the future will show the path," KCR said, even as a chorus of party activists led by his son and TRS working president K.T. Rama Rao (KTR) declared that "India needs a visionary like KCR". The natural corollary to the idea of KCR going national, of course, is also that the legacy and the mantle in Telangana be passed on to the son.

THE PRIMARY NEED IS TO HOLD ON TO TELANGANA. TO ACCOMPLISH THAT, KCR IS TALKING OF SCALING UP TO A NATIONAL ROLE

Analysts believe the BJP is the biggest threat to this plan for intergenerational political longevity, and thus taking it on will now be the single-point agenda for the TRS. KCR's instinctual response to that threat had initially been to try and forge a non-Congress front, but the party's overtures towards others like West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee and NCP chief Sharad Pawar had drawn a tepid response. That has prompted this change in tack—jettisoning talk of a group attack, and offering the picture of a solitary salvo, a stunning



NATIONAL ASPIRATION
KCR (left) and his son KTR (centre) at the plenary on the TRS's 21st foundation day, April 27